Gigabyte GA-Z97X-UD5H-BK

The vanguard of the Z97 brigade has arrived

Intel came out with a processor refresh that includes 20 new SKUs and along with that they've introduced the Z97, H97 and the X99 chipsets. The Z97 in particular is aimed towards replacing the Z87 enthusiast segment maintaining overclocking abilities and bringing with it a host of new technologies. These new chipsets still use the LGA1150 socket so you can use current gen Haswell as well as the soon to be introduced Broadwell processors. The Gigabyte Z97-UD5H-BK is the first Z97 board that we've had the pleasure of testing. The colour scheme of this particular board happens to be black with golden accents. There is a little bit of grey here and there but the overall theme is dark with a matte black PCB to top it off.

This board has support for 3000 MHz RAM through overclocking as is the case with premium boards – kids, now you know that you're playing at the playground where the big boys come to play. The new chipsets also bring support for RAID on all SATA 3 ports so you can now have enterprise class transfer speeds using simple desktop SSDs. Another thing that has been made official on the Z97 chipset is support for SATA Express and the M.2 slot. Both of them use the same bus which is a combination of SATA and PCIE to increase the overall bandwidth available. This means that both ports cannot be used at the same time and since the SATA Express port makes use of two normal SATA ports, it also makes them unavailable. So you can either use the two SATA ports or use the SATA Express port or use the M.2 port. The M.2 port is placed such that it isn't going to be overshadowed by any PCIE card and there will always be a good amount of incidental air-flow over it. Over the last year we've seen most SSDs nearing the 600MBps limit on SATA3 slots so the SATA Express being made part of the chipset is a boon that has come at the right time.

The placement of the VRM heatsinks does make room for big coolers whose fins are at least 25mm from the surface of the board. The POST LEDs are placed awkwardly, if the USB 3.0 header right next to it were to be populated then it will hide the display which negates the purpose of the feature. All the switches have been placed together which is more convenient for benchmarking in an open-air configuration. There is a multitude of PCIE slots and PCI slots which have been made possible due to multiplexing. This board uses Asmedia's ASM1480 for enabling this many slots. There are three physical PCIE x16 slots of which one is wired for x16 while the other two have been wired for x8 and x4 bandwidth. This means that you can have a three-way CrossFire setup or a two-way SLI setup since SLI require a bare minimum of x8 bandwidth per card. Not bad, eh?

Price
₹17,500

The audio is enabled by an Realtek ALC1150 and the section of the motherboard that has this audio chipset seems to be pretty isolated from the rest of the board to ensure as less interference as possible – which is a good move by the designers. The board uses Intel's Gigabit Ethernet and Killer E2201 to give you two gigabit ethernet port but teaming is not supported on these two ports. Also, it's a welcome change to see more USB 3.0 ports on the back compared to USB 2.0 though they haven't done away with USB 2.0 completely and won't do so in the near future.

This is a Black Edition motherboard which means it is aimed towards the higher mid-range segment of users. Each board comes with a certificate attesting to the fact that these boards have been stress tested continuously for an entire week. Another thing we'd like to point out is that these boards come with sleeved SATA cables which look the same as most sleeved power supply cables, something that enthusiast builders have to manually make. Moreover, these come with a five year warranty to sweeten the deal.

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Specifications

Chipset: Intel Z97; **Memory support:** 4x3000(OC)MHz upto 32GB; **LAN:** Killer E2201 Gigabit Ethernet; **Audio:** ALC1150 7.1; **SATA:** 8x SATA III; **Expansion:** PCIe x16, 2x PCIe X16(x8+x4); **Dimensions (LxWxD):** 305 mm x 244 mm; **Warranty:** 3 years

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